

PINK PANTHERS

THE IPL CAN BECOME INDIA'S CONTRIBUTION TO THE GLOBAL WORLD OF BRANDS AND STILL WILL POSE NO DANGER TO TRADITIONAL CRICKET

I started as a cricketer in the 1970s playing for Rajasthan. I moved into advertising in the 1980s and remained there ever since. When Ogilvy was appointed the agency for the IPL in January this year, it was the coming together of my two greatest passions—cricket and communication. The '*sone pe suhaga*' was when Rajasthan Royals enlisted Ogilvy's help to promote their team as a partner. It was a dream.

When we started working on the IPL, we knew we were into something big, something new, that had never been attempted before. Naturally, there was trepidation—would it work? We knew though that we had the right ingredients—cricket, cinema, media and business houses—all coming together to create one big extravaganza.

The IPL committee showed its confidence in the product by backing it, willing to do everything to create maximum buzz and excitement. The results are there to be seen. The TRPs were higher than expected and consistent throughout the tournament; stadia were packed; sponsors got in midway as the momentum for the IPL grew and it has created enough debates in the streets. There is much to learn for brand marketers on how to believe and back a new product. No half measures.

Cricketing gurus had declared Rajasthan Royals as the weakest team. I was fortunate that Ogilvy was appointed by this team—my homeland—to build its brand. We decided to take the tack of the underdog—no talk about winning but a focus on the attack. '*Halla bol*' was the clarion call, in keeping with the spirit of Rajasthan and the Rajputs and also of captain Shane Warne.

As long as the spirit remained positive and aggressive, the results took care of themselves. The work showed the spirit of the young, creative team and music directors led by Ila Arun who were full of earthy passion and energy. So when the Royals emerged winners, it was an emotional moment for me personally. Much of the credit goes to the team management which managed to get the best out of the players. And of course, to the players who performed on the field. It was a real pleasure to be the 'bard' for the winners.

What makes the victory special is the fact that it gave Jaipur something to cheer about after its terrible bomb blasts last month. It was overwhelming to see fans turn up in big numbers at the Sawai Man Singh stadium to cheer

their team. I will never forget the touching ceremony—the blowing of bugles as homage to the blast victims—before the start of the very first match played at the stadium after the blasts.

Will the IPL sound the death of the longer version of the game? Not at all. We underestimate the ability of the human being. He has the ability to juggle and manage many things and find a role for each in his life. Television was supposed to kill radio and cinema. Now Internet is supposed to kill television. It just doesn't happen that way. Each will find its own space in life. To make a person laugh, you need just 30 seconds; to get someone involved, empathise and cry you need longer durations. There are times when one wants to interact, the Net comes in, in other times, when one

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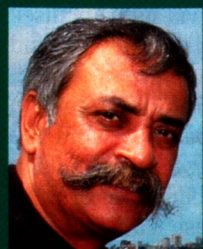


CHAMPIONS: The Rajasthan Royals players after winning the first DLF IPL trophy

wants to be a passive recipient, television and radio come in. Multiple formats will coexist catering to different emotions—*rasas*—of the cricket aficionados. Test cricket will be for those times when one wants to relax and enjoy the beauty of the game and the intellectual struggle between bat and ball. Twenty20 will be the quick fix dose of escapism, much like a movie.

The IPL was Lalit Modi's dream for many years. Credit goes to him and the BCCI that they have managed to pull it off seamlessly in less than four months. It's a testimony of their passion and commitment to the game. I feel the IPL has the potential to leave its footprint globally and become India's contribution to the global brand world. ■

PIYUSH PANDEY



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